BENGALI COLLECTION

NO. 03



WEST BENGAL ORIGIN

# Aloo Posto

❀

Potatoes in Poppy Seed Paste

Bengal's Beloved Everyday Comfort Dish

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

# LICENSE & COPYRIGHT NOTICE

## Aloo Posto

Sold via: Gumroad
Publisher: DhanioDigital  (dhaniodigital.gumroad.com)

**PERSONAL USE LICENSE**

This digital cookbook is licensed for personal, non-commercial use only.
You may print one (1) copy for your own kitchen use.

**YOU MAY NOT:**

- Share, resell, or redistribute this file in any form
- Upload to any website, cloud service, or file-sharing platform
- Remove or obscure any watermarks, copyright notices, or branding
- Use recipes for commercial food service without written permission

Violation of this license may result in legal action.

© 2024 DhanioDigital. All rights reserved.
Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

# Aloo Posto

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

COPYRIGHT

© 2026 Sweta Verma. All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced or distributed without written permission from the publisher.

DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

# A Dish Born of Colonial-Era Poppy Fields

Few ingredients are as closely tied to Bengali identity as posto — poppy seeds — and aloo posto, potatoes cooked in a paste of ground poppy seeds, is perhaps the simplest and most beloved expression of that relationship. The connection has a specific historical root: during the colonial era, the East India Company and later the British administration cultivated poppy extensively across Bengal and Bihar for the opium trade, and the seeds, a byproduct with no role in opium production, became widely and cheaply available to local populations.

Bengali cooks embraced posto not out of necessity alone but genuine culinary appreciation, discovering that ground poppy seeds created a uniquely creamy, nutty paste unlike anything else in Indian cooking, and built an entire category of dishes around it — posto with potatoes, with eggplant, with beans, and more. Aloo posto, the simplest of these, became a fixture of daily Bengali home cooking, the kind of dish made without much ceremony on any ordinary weeknight.

Today, poppy seed availability is more restricted in some countries due to narcotics regulations, giving aloo posto a slightly bittersweet status for the Bengali diaspora abroad — a beloved home dish that can be genuinely difficult to recreate depending on where you live, making it all the more treasured when the ingredients can be found.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

## A Dish Born of Colonial-Era Poppy Fields, continued

### CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Deeply tied to Bengal's colonial-era history of poppy cultivation for the opium trade, with poppy seeds as an incidental byproduct that became a beloved local ingredient. One of the simplest, most everyday dishes in Bengali home cooking, made regularly without much ceremony. A dish that carries particular nostalgic weight for the Bengali diaspora, given that poppy seed availability varies significantly by country due to regulations. Represents Bengali cuisine's distinctive use of ground seeds and nuts as thickening and flavoring agents.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

AT A GLANCE

# Equipment & preparation

| 10m | 25m | 4 | Easy |
|---|---|---|---|
| ACTIVE PREP | COOK TIME | SERVINGS | DIFFICULTY |

## Recommended equipment

- Small blender or mortar and pestle, for the poppy seed paste
- Kadai or wide pan
- Wooden spoon

### STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Aloo posto keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days, though its texture is best enjoyed fresh — poppy seed pastes can thicken considerably as they sit. Reheat gently with a small splash of water to loosen the consistency back to its original creaminess.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

# Ingredients

## For the dish

| INGREDIENT | US | METRIC | INDIAN |
|---|---|---|---|
| Potatoes, cut into cubes | 4 medium | 500 g | 4 medium |
| Poppy seeds (posto) | 3 tbsp | 30 g | 3 spoons |
| Green chili | 2–3 | 2–3 | 2–3 |
| Mustard oil | 3 tbsp | 45 ml | 3 spoons |
| Nigella seeds (kalonji) | ¼ tsp | 1 g | ¼ spoon |
| Turmeric powder | ½ tsp | 1.5 g | ½ spoon |
| Water | ½ cup | 120 ml | ½ bowl |
| Salt | 1 tsp | 6 g | As per taste |

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Poppy seeds are the defining ingredient of this dish, and unfortunately have no true substitute — their unique creamy, nutty texture when ground can't be replicated by other seeds. Where legally available, look for white poppy seeds specifically labeled for culinary use at Indian grocers. Where restricted, this dish may need to be set aside for when you can source them, or you might explore other Bengali potato preparations as an alternative. Mustard oil contributes significantly to the dish's authentic pungent flavor — a neutral oil is a workable but noticeably milder substitute.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

# Making the Poppy Seed Paste

**01** SOAK THE POPPY SEEDS

Soak the poppy seeds in warm water for at least 30 minutes — this softens them considerably and makes grinding to a smooth paste much easier.

**02** GRIND TO A SMOOTH PASTE

Drain and grind the soaked poppy seeds with the green chilies and a little water to a completely smooth, pale paste.





© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

# Making the Poppy Seed Paste, continued

**Chef tip.** poppy seeds can be stubborn to grind smoothly — a small, powerful blender or a mortar and pestle with patience gives the best results, avoiding a gritty texture.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The paste should be completely smooth with no visible seed texture remaining, pale and slightly creamy in appearance.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

# Cooking the Potatoes

**03** TEMPER THE NIGELLA SEEDS

Heat mustard oil in a kadai until it just begins to shimmer, then add the nigella seeds, letting them sizzle for a few seconds.

**04** FRY THE POTATOES

Add the cubed potatoes and turmeric, stirring to coat evenly. Fry for 5–6 minutes, until the potatoes develop light golden edges.





© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

# Cooking the Potatoes, continued

## 05 ADD THE POPPY SEED PASTE

Stir in the poppy seed paste, water, and salt. Cover and simmer for 12–15 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the potatoes are completely tender and the paste has thickened into a creamy coating.

**Texture indicator.** the finished dish should have a thick, creamy, pale coating clinging to each potato piece, with little to no separate liquid remaining.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Grinding the poppy seeds without soaking first is the most common cause of a gritty, unpleasant texture. Always soak for at least 30 minutes before grinding.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

SERVING & PAIRING

# How to serve



## Traditional Style

- Served hot with plain steamed rice and a drizzle of mustard oil, a simple, everyday Bengali lunch.
- Often the centerpiece of a light vegetarian meal alongside dal and a simple green vegetable.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

SERVING & PAIRING

# How to serve, continued

## Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl as part of a Bengali thali, alongside rice, dal, and other vegetable dishes.

## Family Style

- A quick, dependable weeknight side dish that comes together easily alongside rice and dal.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

# Chef secrets

## Getting the Texture Right

- Soaking the poppy seeds thoroughly before grinding is the single most important step for a smooth, creamy result.
- Cooking the potatoes covered helps them become tender without needing excessive stirring, which can break them apart.

## Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The poppy seed paste can be made a few hours ahead and refrigerated, though it's best used the same day for optimal freshness.
- This dish comes together quickly enough that it's rarely necessary to prepare it far in advance.

RESTAURANT TRICK

A small pinch of sugar, though not traditional in every household, is added by some Bengali cooks to round out the poppy seed's natural nuttiness — a subtle, optional touch.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BONUS CONTENT

# Nutrition, variations & FAQ

## APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

| 210 kcal | 4 g | 28 g | 10 g | 3 g |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| CALORIES | PROTEIN | CARBOHYDRATES | FAT | FIBER |

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

### ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

## REGIONAL VARIATIONS

| | |
|---|---|
| **Begun Posto** | eggplant cooked in the same poppy seed paste, a popular variation. |
| **Sheem Posto** | flat beans cooked in poppy seed paste, another common household version. |
| **Aloo Posto with Kalo Jeere** | a version emphasizing nigella seed for extra pungency. |

## Can I buy poppy seeds everywhere?

Availability varies by country due to narcotics regulations — check your local laws and grocers, as some regions restrict or regulate poppy seed sales.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BONUS CONTENT

# Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

## Why is my poppy seed paste gritty?

Almost always insufficient soaking time before grinding. Soak for at least 30 minutes, longer if your blender isn't very powerful.

## Is this dish very spicy?

No — it's typically mild, with the green chilies providing gentle warmth rather than significant heat. Adjust the chili quantity to your preference.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

REFERENCE

# Ingredient glossary





© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

REFERENCE

# Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

| | |
|---|---|
| **Posto** | Bengali for poppy seeds, the defining ingredient of this dish. |
| **Kalonji** | nigella seeds, used for tempering, adding a distinctive sharp aroma. |
| **Aloo** | Hindi/Bengali for potato, the base vegetable of this dish. |
| **Sorshe Tel** | Bengali for mustard oil, essential to authentic flavor in this cuisine. |



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

# Aloo Posto

| 10m | 25m |
|---|---|
| ACTIVE PREP | COOK TIME |
| **4** | **Easy** |
| SERVINGS | DIFFICULTY |

## DISH

| | |
|---|---|
| Potatoes | 500 g |
| Poppy seeds | 30 g |
| Green chili | 2–3 |
| Mustard oil | 45 ml |
| Nigella seeds | 1 g |
| Turmeric powder | 1.5 g |
| Water | 120 ml |
| Salt | 6 g |

## METHOD

01 **Soak the poppy seeds.** Soak the poppy seeds in warm water for at least 30 minutes — this softens them considerably and makes grinding to a smooth paste much easier.

02 **Grind to a smooth paste.** Drain and grind the soaked poppy seeds with the green chilies and a little water to a completely smooth, pale paste.

03 **Temper the nigella seeds.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai until it just begins to shimmer, then add the nigella seeds, letting them sizzle for a few seconds.

04 **Fry the potatoes.** Add the cubed potatoes and turmeric, stirring to coat evenly.

05 **Add the poppy seed paste.** Stir in the poppy seed paste, water, and salt.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BEFORE YOU SHOP

# Shopping list

| | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Potatoes | 500 g |
| ☐ Green chili | 2–3 |
| ☐ Nigella seeds | 1 g |
| ☐ Salt | 6 g |
| ☐ Poppy seeds | 30 g |
| ☐ Mustard oil | 45 ml |
| ☐ Turmeric powder | 1.5 g |



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com